

**Cool summers are stormy summers: precession reorganizes extratropical
cyclone activity through the quiet season**

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7 ABSTRACT: Extratropical cyclones peak in winter, while orbital precession reshapes the sea-
8 sonal insolation cycle most strongly in summer. Thus storm tracks might be expected to ignore the
9 precession cycle. This is examined with twelve equilibrium simulations using a coupled climate
10 model AWI-ESM2, spanning a full precession cycle at 30° longitude increments under fixed eccen-
11 tricity and obliquity. Extratropical cyclones are explicitly tracked based on 6-hourly atmospheric
12 pressure fields for both hemispheres. While the annual-mean cyclone response to precession is
13 muted, substantial seasonal variability emerges. In the North Atlantic, the North Pacific, and the
14 Southern Ocean the response concentrates in local summer, where storm activity ranges across
15 the phases by up to 68% of its climatological mean, while winter changes stay below about 10%.
16 We also find summers spent near perihelion feature suppressed storminess, whereas summers near
17 aphelion experience intensified cyclone activity, yielding antiphase midlatitude storm variability
18 between the two hemispheres over the precession cycle. This signal is carried by cyclone number
19 and position rather than by propagation speed, and it follows the pronounced summer response
20 of the Eady growth rate driven primarily by vertical shear in all three basins. Monthly storm
21 responses are phase-locked to the calendar timing of perihelion, lagged by 1–2 months due to
22 surface thermal inertia. Precession therefore acts on extratropical storm tracks through their quiet
23 season. Summer-sensitive proxy archives should record a strong and hemispherically antiphased
24 storminess signal at the precession period that annually integrating archives would miss.

25 SIGNIFICANCE STATEMENT: Long orbital cycles drive global climate variability, and the
26 strongest of these, precession, reshapes sunlight mainly in summer, while mid-latitude storms
27 happen mainly in winter. This creates an apparent disconnect between precessional forcing and
28 storm track variability. Climate model simulations covering a full precession cycle show that
29 the orbit nevertheless controls storminess by acting through summer. When perihelion falls in a
30 hemisphere's summer, that summer has fewer mid-latitude storms and the storm belt sits farther
31 poleward, and the two hemispheres evolve in antiphase through the precession cycle. This tells
32 researchers where to look for orbital storm signals in geological records, namely in archives
33 sensitive to summer, not to the yearly average.

34 1. Introduction

35 Extratropical cyclones organize the weather of the middle latitudes. They carry most of the
36 poleward heat and moisture transport outside the tropics, deliver a large share of midlatitude
37 precipitation, and cluster into the storm tracks of the North Atlantic, the North Pacific, and the
38 Southern Ocean (Hoskins and Valdes 1990; Chang et al. 2002; Hoskins and Hodges 2002, 2005).
39 These storms grow by baroclinic instability on the meridional temperature gradient (Eady 1949),
40 and the gradient is steepest in winter. Cyclone numbers therefore peak in the cold season in both
41 hemispheres, in the south as clearly as in the north (Simmonds and Keay 2000). Extratropical
42 cyclones are creatures of winter.

43 Precession, in contrast, is a lever that acts on summer. The slow turning of the longitude of
44 perihelion is the strongest orbital pacemaker of the seasonal insolation cycle, yet it redistributes
45 sunlight rather than adding any, and the redistribution is proportional to the sunlight a season
46 already receives (Berger 1978; Laskar et al. 2004). Midlatitude summer insolation swings by more
47 than 100 W m^{-2} across a precession cycle while midwinter insolation barely moves, which is why
48 the orbital literature treats summer energy as the climatically active quantity (Huybers 2006). A
49 winter phenomenon facing a summer lever invites a simple expectation. Precession should have
50 little to say about storm tracks. That expectation has never been put to a clean test.

51 Where the imprint of precession has been studied in depth, it appears as a seasonal reorganization
52 of climate rather than a change in the annual mean. The monsoon literature carries this tradition,
53 from the classic orbital experiments of Kutzbach and Guetter (1986) to single-forcing designs that

isolate precession explicitly (Bosmans et al. 2015; Merlis et al. 2013), and cave records show the northern and southern monsoons swinging in antiphase as perihelion migrates through the year (Wang et al. 2008). The extratropics have received far less attention. Kaspar et al. (2007) simulated a stronger and poleward-shifted North Atlantic winter storm track for the Eemian from two orbital time slices, Brayshaw et al. (2010) traced Holocene orbital forcing into the North Atlantic and Mediterranean winter storm tracks through the baroclinicity they support, and Varma et al. (2012) found the Southern Hemisphere westerlies migrating under Holocene orbital forcing. Explicit cyclone tracking has entered paleoclimate work mainly at the Last Glacial Maximum, where ice sheets dominate the forcing (Pinto and Ludwig 2020; Raible et al. 2021), and in transient simulations of the last millennium (Hess and Chemke 2025). For tropical cyclones the precessional response has recently been isolated in high-resolution paleoclimate simulations (Raavi et al. 2023). To our knowledge, no previous study has applied explicit cyclone tracking across a full precession cycle to isolate the orbital response of the extratropical storm tracks.

Closing this gap matters beyond dynamics. However, the paleoclimate records that would register past storminess, from dust and wind-blown sediment to westerly-belt precipitation, respond to particular seasons rather than to the annual mean, and a seasonally biased archive can fabricate or erase an orbital signal depending on which season carries it (Laepple et al. 2011). Knowing where in the seasonal cycle the precessional storm signal lives is a prerequisite for reading such records. Storm diagnostics raise a parallel issue, because measures of cyclone influence time, cyclone counts, and cyclone intensity respond to forcing in different ways and must be separated before any single proxy is interpreted.

In the present study the precession cycle is covered with twelve equilibrium simulations of a coupled climate model, and every extratropical cyclone is tracked explicitly in six-hourly pressure fields in both hemispheres. The design isolates precession at amplified eccentricity with all other boundary conditions fixed, so that the seasonal anatomy of the orbital storm response can be mapped basin by basin against the calendar month of perihelion.

The naive expectation fails, and it fails in an instructive way. The annual-mean storm response is indeed small, but the signal has not vanished. It is concentrated in local summer, the quiet season, in all three storm basins. Summers spent near perihelion are calm and summers spent near aphelion are stormy, so the two hemispheres respond in antiphase across the precession cycle, an

84 extratropical counterpart of the monsoon seesaw. The response travels from insolation to storms
85 through the summer Eady growth rate, and the growth-rate change is carried by vertical shear
86 (Lindzen and Farrell 1980). The paper is organized around which season carries the precessional
87 storm response, what dynamical chain transmits it, and why the winter storm track stays orbitally
88 quiet. Section 2 describes the model, the ensemble, and the tracking. Section 3 presents the
89 seasonal anatomy of the response, and section 4 discusses mechanisms, implications for proxy
90 records, and limitations.

91 **2. Data and methods**

92 *a. Model and experiments*

93 The simulations are performed with the coupled Earth system model AWI-ESM2 (Sidorenko
94 et al. 2019; Shi et al. 2022). The atmosphere component is ECHAM6 at T63 resolution with 47
95 vertical levels (Stevens et al. 2013), which includes the land surface module JSBACH (Raddatz
96 et al. 2007). The ocean and sea ice component is FESOM2, a finite-volume model formulated on
97 an unstructured mesh (Danilov et al. 2017).

98 Twelve equilibrium simulations are analyzed, taken from the idealized precession ensemble
99 introduced by Shi et al. (2025). The longitude of perihelion ω is prescribed at values from 0° to
100 330° in steps of 30° , while eccentricity is fixed at 0.058 and obliquity at 24.5° . The eccentricity
101 value sits near the upper bound reached during the Quaternary and amplifies the precessional
102 modulation of insolation, so that the response emerges clearly from internal variability. All
103 remaining boundary conditions follow the preindustrial setup, and each phase is branched from
104 a long preindustrial control. Thirty years of six-hourly output from the equilibrated part of each
105 simulation form the basis of the cyclone analysis. The calendar month of perihelion for each phase
106 is computed from two-body orbital geometry (Berger 1978), and the same formulary provides the
107 insolation fields shown in Fig. 1.

108 *b. Cyclone detection and tracking*

109 Extratropical cyclones are detected and tracked with the algorithm of Crawford et al. (2021),
110 and Fig. 2 summarizes the procedure with one six-hourly field of the ensemble. Six-hourly sea
111 level pressure is first interpolated onto 100-km equal-area grids centered on each pole, and the two

hemispheres are processed separately. A grid cell qualifies as a cyclone center when its pressure p_c lies below that of all eight neighbors and the surrounding field keeps a sufficient inward gradient. The gradient test compares p_c with the mean pressure $\bar{p}(d)$ on a one-cell ring at distance d from the candidate,

$$\frac{\bar{p}(d) - p_c}{d} \geq \gamma, \quad d = 1000 \text{ km}, \quad \gamma = 750 \text{ Pa (1000 km)}^{-1}, \quad (1)$$

and candidates over terrain above 1500 m are discarded. Centers closer than 1000 km are treated as one multicenter system. The cyclone area A is obtained by growing closed isobars around each center at a 200-Pa interval until a contour fails to close, and the last closed isobar defines the edge pressure p_e (Fig. 2b). Each cyclone carries the depth and the area-equivalent radius

$$D = p_e - p_c, \quad R = \sqrt{A/\pi}. \quad (2)$$

Tracking links the centers of consecutive six-hourly fields (Fig. 2c). For every active cyclone a first-guess position is projected from its previous displacement, damped to three quarters,

$$\mathbf{x}_q = \mathbf{x}_t + 0.75 (\mathbf{x}_t - \mathbf{x}_{t-1}), \quad (3)$$

and a center of the next field qualifies as the continuation when it lies within $v_{\max}\Delta t$ of both the current position $\mathbf{x}_t$ and the projection $\mathbf{x}_q$, with $v_{\max} = 150 \text{ km h}^{-1}$ and $\Delta t = 6 \text{ h}$. Among the qualifying candidates the one nearest to the projection continues the track. Centers left unmatched at the new time start tracks as genesis events, and tracks left unmatched end as lysis. Only systems poleward of 30° latitude enter the analysis.

Several track-based diagnostics are derived. Track density counts every six-hourly cyclone position, system density counts each cyclone once at its mean position, and genesis density counts the first point of each track. Tracks that merely cross the boundaries of the monthly processing windows would appear as spurious genesis or lysis events, and such truncated events (about 7% of the total) are removed. For every cyclone the lifespan, the maximum depth relative to the outermost closed isobar, the minimum central pressure, the mean cyclone area, and the propagation speed are recorded.

134 *c. Gridded storm coverage*

135 A complementary Eulerian diagnostic measures how long each location spends under cyclone
136 influence. At every six-hourly time step a binary mask flags the grid cells that lie inside a square
137 search window of half-width $\sqrt{A}$ grid cells around each cyclone center and whose pressure lies
138 below the edge pressure of that cyclone,

$$M(\mathbf{x}, t) = 1 \quad \text{where } p(\mathbf{x}, t) < p_e \text{ inside the window,} \quad (4)$$

139 and the masks are regridded to T63 and accumulated into monthly storm days, one quarter of
140 the flagged six-hourly steps. Storm days at a point therefore scale with the product of cyclone
141 number and cyclone area footprint. The two factors can carry opposite seasonal cycles, and over
142 the Southern Ocean the larger size of summer cyclones raises summertime storm days even though
143 cyclone counts peak in winter. Frequency statements in this paper consequently rest on the track-
144 based densities, while storm days serve as a smooth field for maps and for measures of cyclone
145 influence time. The gridded product covers all twelve phases. An early processing inconsistency
146 in the $\omega = 30^\circ$ mask product was traced to a stale intermediate file and removed by regenerating
147 the storm masks of all twelve experiments with one pipeline version, and the regenerated fields
148 were verified month by month against the Lagrangian statistics.

149 An Eulerian measure of synoptic variability provides a further check that involves no tracking
150 at all. Bandpass sea level pressure variability is computed from the six-hourly fields with the 24-h
151 difference filter of Wallace et al. (1988), which isolates fluctuations on the synoptic time scales that
152 define the classical storm tracks (Blackmon 1976), and its monthly standard deviation is analyzed
153 with the same basins, seasons, and response measures (appendix Fig. A1).

154 *d. Baroclinicity diagnostics*

155 The maximum Eady growth rate serves as the measure of baroclinicity (Eady 1949; Lindzen
156 and Farrell 1980; Hoskins and Valdes 1990). It is computed as $\sigma = 0.31 |f| |\partial U / \partial z| N^{-1}$ in the
157 925–700 hPa layer from monthly wind, temperature, and geopotential height. The response to
158 precession is quantified between the end members p090 and p270, which place perihelion at the
159 June and December solstices. Because the difference fields are dipolar, plain box averages cancel,

160 and the response amplitude is instead defined as the root-mean-square of the difference over a
161 basin, normalized by the climatological growth rate of the season. A substitution decomposition
162 in the style of Camargo et al. (2007) splits the difference field into a vertical-shear factor and a
163 static-stability factor, and the share of each factor is obtained by projecting it onto the full difference
164 pattern. The basin averages use the storm-track boxes defined below. This choice matters in the
165 Southern Hemisphere, where a sector beginning at 30°S would admit the seasonal signal of the
166 subtropical winter jet and disguise it as a storm-belt response.

167 *e. Basins and statistics*

168 Three storm-track basins are analyzed, the North Atlantic (30–75°N, 80°W–20°E), the North
169 Pacific (30–75°N, 120°E–120°W), and the Southern Ocean (40–75°S, all longitudes). Basin means
170 are area weighted. The size of the precessional response is reported as the range across the twelve
171 phases, the maximum minus the minimum of the 30-year mean, expressed as a percentage of
172 the phase mean. Uncertainty estimates use the interannual spread of the 30 individual years in
173 each phase, and the significance of the end-member difference maps is assessed with a two-sided
174 Welch t test at each grid point. The local-summer contrasts between extreme phases far exceed the
175 interannual noise, with p values below 10^{-12} in all three basins.

176 **3. Results**

177 *a. Winter storm tracks and what storm days measure*

178 The three storm tracks of the ensemble live in winter, exactly as observed. Seasonal-mean genesis
179 counts peak in DJF over the North Atlantic and the North Pacific and in JJA over the Southern
180 Ocean, and system counts follow the same calendar in every phase. Cyclones also cut deepest in
181 the cold season, with winter maximum depths exceeding their summer values by roughly half in the
182 northern basins. The winter identity of the storm season is therefore common to both hemispheres
183 and to all twelve orbital configurations (Fig. 4a–c; Table 1).

184 The gridded storm-day field tells a partly different story, and the difference is instructive. Basin-
185 mean storm days over the Southern Ocean stay high through austral summer although summer
186 cyclones are fewer. The elevation reflects cyclone size rather than cyclone number. Summer
187 systems there are about twenty percent larger in area than their winter counterparts, and storm days

count the time a grid cell spends inside any cyclone, so the product of number and footprint hides the winter peak in counts. A diagnostic of cyclone influence time is not a diagnostic of cyclone frequency, and the two must be read together. Frequency statements below therefore rest on the track-based densities, while storm days provide the smooth fields used for maps.

b. The summer paradox

The annual-mean view sets the baseline (Fig. 3). The twelve annual climatologies are close to interchangeable, and the anomalies of each phase from their common mean form weak, smoothly rotating dipoles along the storm tracks. The basin series beneath the maps quantify how little survives in the annual mean, with across-phase ranges of 10%, 17% and 4% in the North Atlantic, the North Pacific and the Southern Ocean, varying smoothly with ω and already hinting at the interhemispheric antiphase, since the northern basins reach their minima near $\omega = 90^\circ$ where the Southern Ocean peaks.

Precession barely touches the annual mean but reorganizes the seasons, and the season it selects is the quiet one. The seasonal cycles of basin-mean track density keep their winter peak in every phase and fan out across the phases almost exclusively in local summer (Fig. 4a–c). The across-phase range makes this quantitative (Fig. 4d–f). In the North Pacific the annual range is 7% of the phase mean while the JJA range reaches 44%. The North Atlantic behaves the same way with 7% against 25%. The Southern Ocean repeats the pattern half a year out of phase, with an annual range of 4% against 22% in DJF. System and genesis densities confirm the calendar in every basin, and the influence-time metric swings harder still, with a storm-day range of 68% in North Pacific summer (Table 1). The sensitive season is local summer everywhere, and the small annual signal is what survives of a substantial summer swing after the stable winter is averaged in.

A tracking-free view points the same way (appendix Fig. A1). Bandpass sea level pressure variability responds most strongly in JJA over the North Pacific, at 36% of its climatology against 9% in winter, and winter holds the weakest response of all seasons in both northern basins. This amplitude-weighted metric shifts part of the response within the warm half-year. Over the North Atlantic it peaks in early autumn, matching the secondary September lobe of the forcing itself (Fig. 1c), and over the Southern Ocean its apparent winter share lies on the equatorward flank of

216 the basin box, while poleward of 50°S austral summer leads. The warm-season concentration and
217 the winter quiescence are therefore not artifacts of the tracking algorithm.

218 *c. Orbital anchoring and the interhemispheric mirror*

219 The summer response is anchored to the orbit, not to the calendar. When the basin-mean track-
220 density anomaly is drawn as a function of calendar month and precession phase, the anomaly ridge
221 climbs through the diagram along the calendar month of perihelion (Fig. 4g–i). The sign is fixed
222 by the orbital geometry. Summers spent near perihelion are quiet and summers spent near aphelion
223 are stormy. North Pacific summer activity reaches its minimum at $\omega = 90^\circ$, the configuration
224 with perihelion at the June solstice, where it falls 31% below the phase mean, and its maximum
225 of +37% near $\omega = 270^\circ$ (Fig. 7a). The North Atlantic swings between -16% and $+15\%$ at the
226 same phases. The Southern Ocean mirrors this behavior, with a DJF maximum at $\omega = 60^\circ$ and a
227 minimum at $\omega = 210^\circ$, because a perihelion that falls in northern summer is an aphelion summer
228 for the south. One lever thus drives the two hemispheres in antiphase across the precession cycle.
229 The extreme-phase contrasts far exceed interannual variability, with Welch p values below 10^{-12}
230 in all three basins.

231 *d. The dynamical bridge runs through summer shear*

232 The seasonal selectivity begins in the forcing itself. Averaged over the northern storm-track band
233 from 40 to 70°N, the seasonal forcing amplitude peaks at 105 W m^{-2} in JJA and collapses to 14
234 in DJF, and the mirror band in the south peaks at 119 W m^{-2} in DJF against 47 in JJA (Fig. 1).
235 Perihelion can only amplify a season that already receives sunlight, so the orbital lever presses on
236 local summer in each hemisphere, keeps a substantial autumn shoulder, and leaves deep winter
237 almost untouched.

238 Baroclinicity translates the pressure on the seasons into the storm response. The Eady growth
239 rate difference between the end members p090 and p270 is largest in local summer within every
240 storm basin (Fig. 5). Relative to the seasonal climatology the summer response reaches 31% in the
241 North Atlantic, a striking 92% in the North Pacific, and 21% in the Southern Ocean, in each case
242 the seasonal maximum for that basin. A substitution decomposition attributes the pattern almost
243 entirely to the vertical-shear factor, whose projection accounts for 103–109% of the difference field

in the three basins, while the static-stability factor contributes near zero. The chain is short and uniform. Perihelion summers warm the summer hemisphere, flatten the meridional temperature gradient, weaken the thermal-wind shear, and starve the baroclinic growth on which summer cyclones depend. The storm anomalies appear somewhat poleward of the growth-rate anomalies, consistent with the downstream development of baroclinic waves (Chang et al. 2002), and this offset is why pattern measures rather than same-latitude box averages are used throughout. Winter tells a complementary story. The winter growth rate still shifts by 16–18% between the end members, yet the winter storm response stays below 12% in every basin, a point taken up in the discussion.

e. Spatial expression, and what precession actually moves

The end-member difference maps show where the summer signal lives (Fig. 6). In the annual mean the p090 minus p270 difference is weak and patchy. In JJA a pronounced dipole spans the northern basins, with fewer storm days through the midlatitude core and more along the Arctic flank at perihelion summer, the signature of a poleward shift joined to an overall summer weakening. In DJF the significant signal migrates to the Southern Ocean and forms a circumpolar banded structure of opposite sign. About half of the JJA grid points in the northern extratropics pass the 95% significance test, against a far smaller fraction in the annual mean.

The track displacement behind these dipoles can be made explicit (appendix Fig. A2). The storm-day-weighted latitude of the North Pacific summer track migrates from 53°N when perihelion falls in northern winter to 61°N when it falls in northern summer, a poleward excursion of 8° that peaks exactly at $\omega = 90^\circ$, and the track-density-weighted latitude follows the same curve with a 5° swing. The North Atlantic summer track moves 4.4° in the same direction, and the Southern Ocean summer track mirrors the rule with a poleward excursion of 3.8° when perihelion approaches austral summer. A perihelion summer therefore thins the storm population and displaces the survivors poleward, in step with the poleward shift of the baroclinic zone seen in the growth-rate dipole of Fig. 5a. The winter track latitude stays within 1.5–2.8° across the entire cycle, and its small extremes do not align with the solstitial phases, which extends the winter invariance from storm counts to storm position. The shoulder seasons fall in between and carry a telling phase structure, because the autumn excursion peaks near $\omega = 150^\circ$, the configuration that places perihelion in late summer, so the poleward displacement follows the perihelion month through the calendar exactly

273 as the occurrence anomaly does in Fig. 4g–i. The annual-mean track latitude varies by no more
274 than 1.3° in any basin.

275 The orbital anchoring of occurrence and position condenses into a single statement (Fig. 8). A
276 first-harmonic fit across the phases gives, for every calendar month, the value of ω at which storm
277 activity reaches its minimum and the track its poleward maximum, and through the sunlit half-year
278 both sequences climb in parallel with the line that places perihelion in that month. The response
279 lags the perihelion calendar by a basin-dependent interval, near one month in the North Pacific,
280 one to two months in the North Atlantic, and slightly over two months in the Southern Ocean,
281 an ordering consistent with the growing oceanic character of the three sectors and with surface
282 thermal inertia setting the delay. Winter months fall off the line, where the response amplitude is
283 too small to anchor. The storm tracks are phase locked to the perihelion calendar wherever the
284 lever can reach them.

285 What precession moves is above all the number and location of cyclones, not their translation
286 speed, and only regionally their depth (Fig. 7b). Local-summer ranges of the frequency and position
287 metrics span 16–68% across the basins. Propagation speed stays within 2–5% everywhere. Cyclone
288 depth separates the basins, and the diagnostics are deliberately kept apart in the manner of Zappa
289 et al. (2013). Over the Southern Ocean the maximum depth varies by only 4% across the phases
290 while frequency varies by 22%, a clean decoupling of frequency from intensity. Over the North
291 Pacific the summer depth range reaches 33% and the lifespan range 23%, so there the whole
292 cyclone population weakens together when perihelion falls in summer, fewer systems that are also
293 shallower and shorter lived. The North Atlantic sits between these regimes. The common element
294 across basins is that occurrence responds most, while the intensity response ranges from absent to
295 substantial depending on how strongly the summer baroclinic reservoir is drained.

296 *f. What the rain records*

297 The hydrological expression of the cycle runs opposite to the dynamical one (appendix Fig. A3).
298 Detected cyclones deliver about one third of extratropical precipitation in the ensemble, in line
299 with reanalysis-based attribution (Hawcroft et al. 2012). In North Pacific summer the precipitation
300 falling inside each storm strengthens by up to 15% exactly where storm counts collapse, and the
301 two series are nearly perfectly anticorrelated across the phases ($r = -0.95$). A perihelion summer

holds a warmer and moister atmosphere, so the surviving storms rain harder, but the loss of storms wins, and total summer precipitation still falls by 17% between the end members. The share of precipitation delivered by storms falls with it, by 9.5 percentage points across the cycle in North Pacific summer against about 3 in the annual mean. Precession therefore forces extratropical hydroclimate in two opposing ways at once, fewer storms against wetter storms, and the two must be kept apart in interpretation just as counts and depths must.

4. Discussion

a. Why the lever lands in summer

The seasonal selectivity of the storm response is set by orbital geometry before any model physics enters. Precession redistributes insolation in proportion to the insolation a season already has, so the winter hemisphere offers the lever almost nothing to press on (Berger 1978). The monthly forcing amplitude in Fig. 1 makes the floor explicit, with midwinter values near 20 W m^{-2} against summer values above 125 W m^{-2} at the latitudes of the storm tracks. This part of the result is model independent and would reappear in any climate model, because it restates the geometry that also underlies the summer-energy view of orbital forcing (Huybers 2006). The novelty is not that summer receives the forcing, which the monsoon literature established long ago (Kutzbach and Guetter 1986; Bosmans et al. 2015), but that the summer forcing finds a winter phenomenon and reorganizes it through its quiet season.

b. Cool summers are stormy summers

The mechanism that converts summer insolation into summer storms is the thermal wind. Perihelion summers warm the summer hemisphere most strongly over land and at high latitudes, flatten the meridional temperature gradient, and weaken the vertical shear that feeds baroclinic growth. The factor decomposition confirms that the shear term carries essentially the whole Eady growth rate response in all three basins, while static stability contributes almost nothing. The same chain, with greenhouse warming in place of perihelion, is now observed in the present-day Northern Hemisphere, where amplified summer warming at high latitudes has weakened the summer circulation, the eddy kinetic energy, and the number of strong summer cyclones (Coumou et al. 2015; Chang et al. 2016; Gertler and O’Gorman 2019). Projections extend the analogy, with

CMIP-class models thinning summer cyclone activity and the associated baroclinicity through the same shear pathway (Lehmann et al. 2014; Priestley and Catto 2022). The correspondence should be read as a shared mechanism rather than a shared scenario, because the warming trend alters the two hemispheres together whereas precession swings them in antiphase. Under both forcings the rule is the same, and it is the rule in the title. Cool summers are stormy summers.

c. The orbital invariance of the winter storm track

The stability of winter deserves as much attention as the mobility of summer. Winter storm activity varies by less than about a tenth across the entire precession cycle in every basin, and this is only partly a matter of weak winter forcing. The winter Eady growth rate still shifts by 16–18% between the end members, yet winter cyclone numbers barely respond. The winter storm track appears saturated in the sense that ample baroclinicity is available in every phase, so that moderate changes in the growth rate do not translate into changes in occurrence. Whatever its ultimate cause, the practical consequence is notable. The delivery of winter precipitation to the midlatitude and subpolar continents, the season and pathway that build snowpack and feed ice sheets, is essentially fixed across orbital configurations of the precession cycle. A transient simulation of the last millennium likewise found cyclone counts nearly insensitive to external forcing (Raible et al. 2018; Hess and Chemke 2025), and the present result extends that insensitivity to the far larger insolation excursions of the orbital band, for winter alone.

d. One lever, three basins, and what the records would see

The three basins express one mechanism with different accents, and the diagnostics must be kept apart to see it. Occurrence responds everywhere, with local-summer ranges of 16–68% in frequency and position metrics, while propagation speed is inert. Intensity separates the basins. The Southern Ocean decouples cleanly, with a 4% depth range against a 22% frequency range, the North Pacific weakens as a whole population in perihelion summers, and the North Atlantic lies between. The pattern echoes the long-standing conclusion from anthropogenic scenarios that cyclone number and cyclone intensity respond to forcing through different processes and need not move together (Bengtsson et al. 2009; Ulbrich et al. 2009; Catto et al. 2019). The water cycle sharpens the contrast, because per-storm precipitation strengthens in the very summers that lose

358 storms, an orbital counterpart of the warming-scenario finding that hydrological responses outrun
359 dynamical ones (Bengtsson et al. 2009). For the record this matters twice over. Extratropical
360 precipitation is delivered disproportionately by cyclones and their fronts (Hawcroft et al. 2012;
361 Catto and Pfahl 2013), and the storm-attributed share of precipitation swings by up to ten percentage
362 points across the cycle in North Pacific summer, so a precipitation archive senses the competition
363 between fewer storms and wetter storms rather than either alone. The storm-day diagnostic adds
364 its own caution, because cyclone influence time folds cyclone size into cyclone number, and over
365 the Southern Ocean the seasonal cycle of size alone can invert the apparent storm season. Any
366 proxy that integrates storm influence rather than storm counts inherits this ambiguity.

367 For the paleoclimate record the seasonal anatomy carries a concrete and testable message. An
368 archive with summer-biased sensitivity in the midlatitude storm belts should carry a pronounced
369 precession signal in storminess, while an annually integrating archive should carry almost none.
370 The seasonal bias of an archive can therefore fabricate or erase an orbital storm signal exactly as it
371 does for temperature (Laepple et al. 2011). The interhemispheric mirror sharpens the prediction,
372 because summer-sensitive storminess records from the two hemispheres should vary in antiphase
373 at the precession period, the extratropical counterpart of the monsoon seesaw (Wang et al. 2008).
374 Existing archives make the test realistic. Precession-band signals are already established in the
375 northern midlatitude westerlies (Li et al. 2019) and in the composition of North Pacific dust, where
376 the precession imprint sits in the moisture-sensitive component while the annually integrating
377 flux follows obliquity (Zhong et al. 2024), and a winter-integrating dust-strength record shows
378 correspondingly weak precession power (Chen et al. 2014). In the south the westerly belt carries
379 strong 19 and 23 kyr cycles at its subtropical edge (Lamy et al. 2019), with the orbital band
380 recorded at a site depending on its latitude within the belt (Kaiser et al. 2024). The subtropical
381 location of that southern signal is consistent with the present results, because the winter half of
382 the precessional baroclinicity response resides in the subtropical jet equatorward of the storm belt,
383 while the storm-belt response is a summer phenomenon. Records of the southern westerlies also
384 show orbital-band migrations of the belt itself (Lamy et al. 2010; Varma et al. 2012), and glacial-
385 state cyclone modeling has shown how strongly reconstructed storminess depends on which cyclone
386 property a proxy senses (Pinto and Ludwig 2020). A paired-hemisphere test at the precession band
387 is within reach of existing archives.

388 *e. Limitations*

389 Several limitations bound these conclusions. The results rest on one model, one tracking algo-
390 rithm, and an idealized orbital configuration with eccentricity fixed near its Quaternary maximum,
391 so the simulated amplitudes represent an upper bound that scales with $e \sin \omega$ rather than a recon-
392 struction of any particular epoch. Obliquity is fixed at 24.5° , and interactions between precession
393 and obliquity or ice volume are outside the design. The simulations are equilibrium slices, so
394 transient effects along the precession cycle are not represented. The T63 atmosphere resolves
395 the storm tracks but not mesoscale substructure, and low-level Eady growth rates in the Southern
396 Hemisphere carry a documented sensitivity to boundary-layer stability (Simmonds and Lim 2009).
397 The gridded storm-day product required one uniform regeneration of the storm masks before all
398 twelve phases could be used together, a reminder that multi-batch processing of tracked-cyclone
399 products deserves explicit version control.

400 **5. Conclusions**

401 One rule spans the three storm tracks of this precession ensemble. The orbital lever reaches
402 extratropical cyclones through local summer, the quiet season, while the winter storm track stays
403 essentially fixed across the entire cycle. Summers spent near perihelion are calm and summers
404 near aphelion are stormy, and because one hemisphere's perihelion summer is the other's aphelion
405 summer, midlatitude storminess in the two hemispheres swings in antiphase at the precession
406 period. The signal travels through shear-driven summer baroclinicity and expresses itself chiefly
407 in how many cyclones occur and where they run, with per-cyclone intensity responding only where
408 the summer baroclinic reservoir is drained most deeply. Both expressions are phase locked to
409 the calendar month of perihelion, with a delay of one to two months that grows with the oceanic
410 character of the basin. For the proxy record the lesson is direct. Orbital storminess signals should
411 be sought in summer-sensitive midlatitude archives, and they should appear with opposite sign in
412 the two hemispheres.

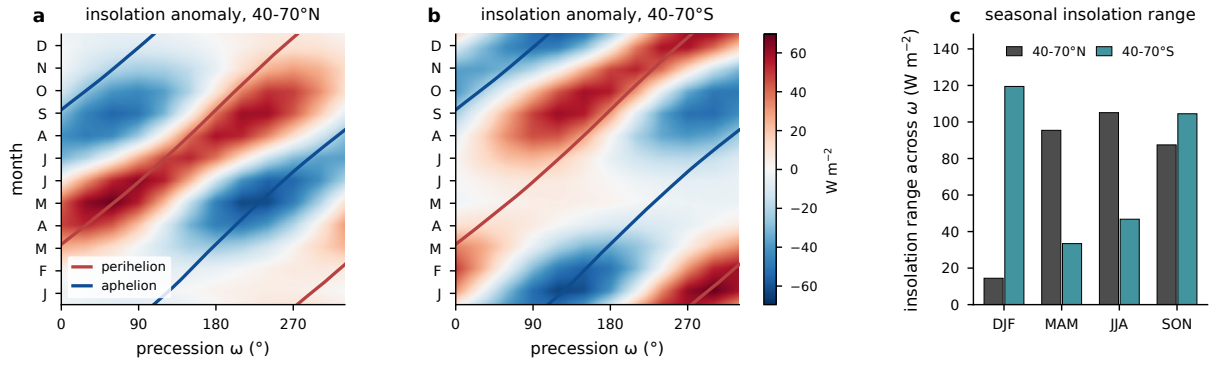
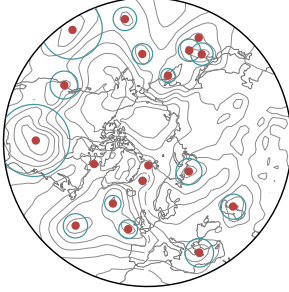
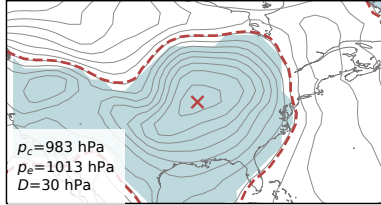


FIG. 1. Precessional insolation forcing from orbital geometry with eccentricity 0.058 and obliquity 24.5° .
 (a) Monthly insolation anomaly relative to the phase mean, averaged over the storm-track band $40\text{--}70^\circ\text{N}$, as
 a function of calendar month and precession phase ω , with the perihelion (red) and aphelion (blue) calendar
 months of each phase overlaid. (b) As in (a), but for $40\text{--}70^\circ\text{S}$. (c) Seasonal forcing amplitude in the two bands,
 the seasonal mean of the monthly maximum minus minimum insolation across the twelve phases. Units: W m^{-2} .

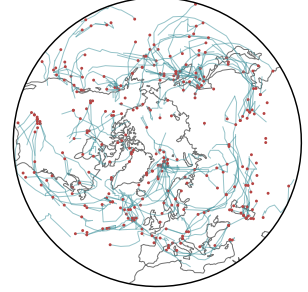
(a) centers + area radii, one 6-h field



(b) outermost closed isobar p_e , mask cells



(c) tracks of one month ($n=407$)



(d)

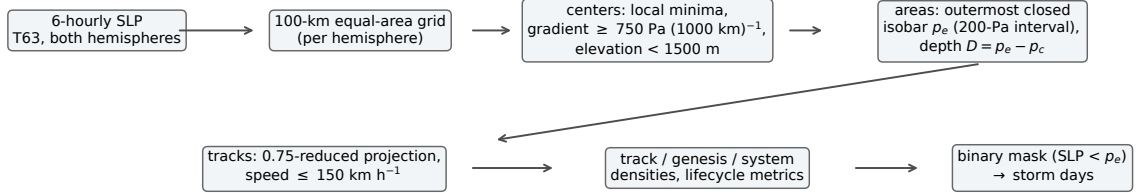


FIG. 2. Cyclone detection and tracking procedure. (a) One six-hourly sea level pressure field of phase p000 (contours, 8-hPa interval) with all detected cyclone centers poleward of 30°N (dots) and their area-equivalent radii $R = \sqrt{A/\pi}$ (circles), 15 January of one model year. (b) The deepest system of that field, with the outermost closed isobar p_e (dashed), the cyclone center (cross), the central and edge pressures and depth annotated, and the binary mask cells (shading) defined by $\text{SLP} < p_e$ inside the $\sqrt{A}$ search window; contour interval 4 hPa. (c) All cyclone tracks of the same month (lines) with genesis points (dots). (d) Processing chain with the key thresholds of Eqs. (1)–(4).

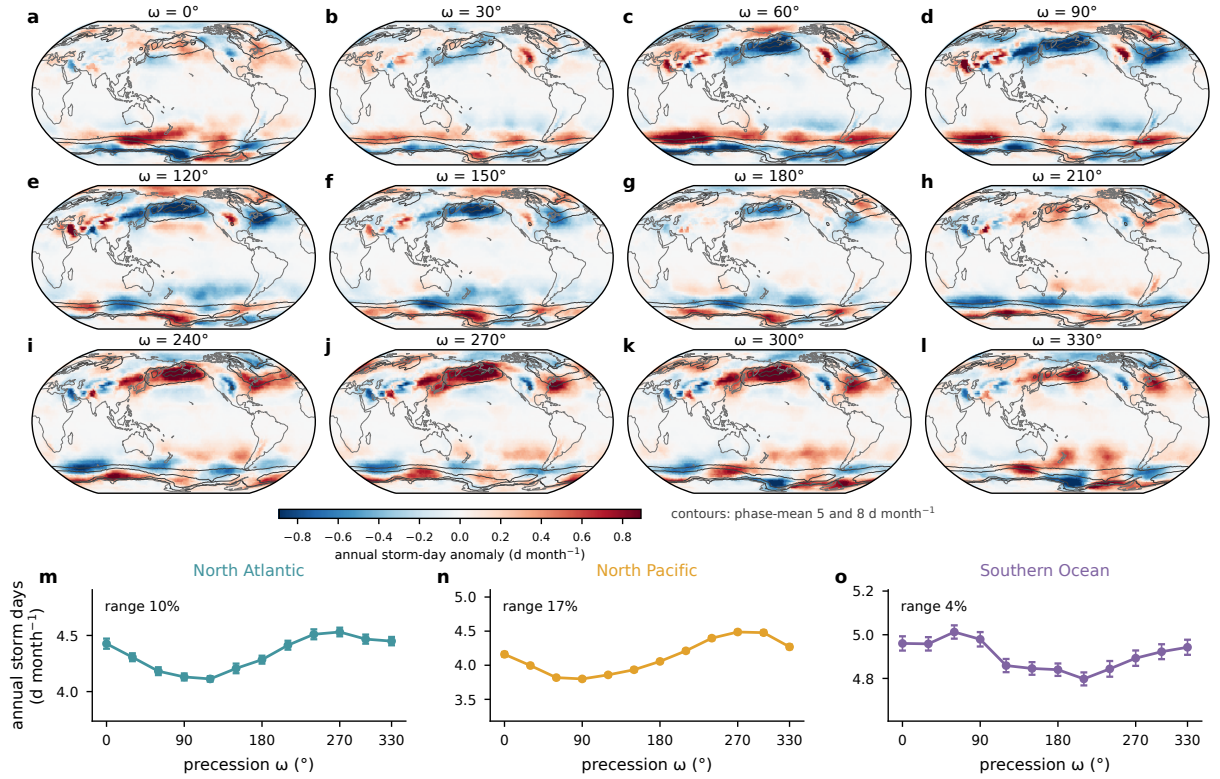


FIG. 3. Annual-mean storm days across the precession cycle. (a)–(l) Annual storm-day anomaly of each phase relative to the twelve-phase mean (shading), with the phase-mean climatology outlined at 5 and 8 d month⁻¹ (contours). (m)–(o) Basin-mean annual storm days against ω with interannual standard errors; the across-phase range as a percentage of the phase mean is annotated in each panel.

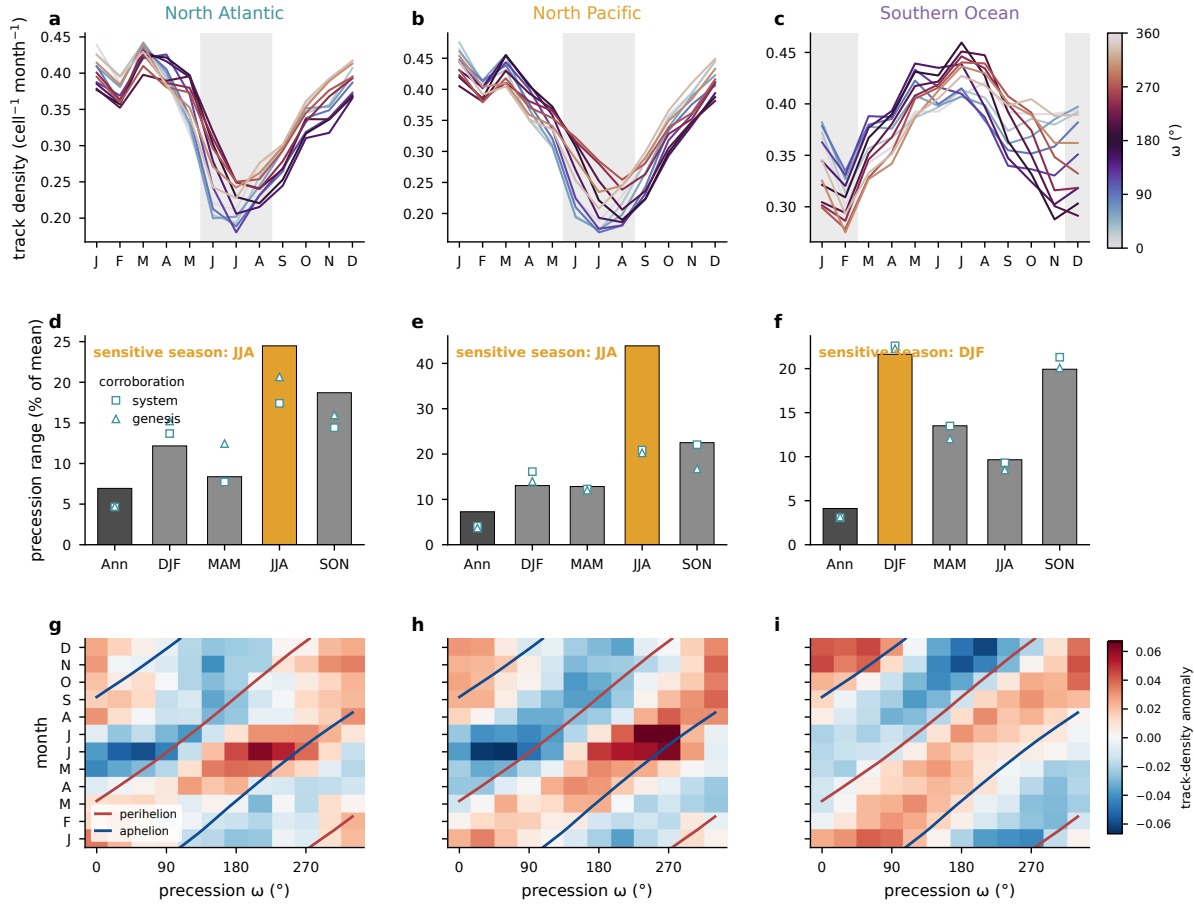


FIG. 4. Seasonal concentration of the precessional storm response, from the Lagrangian tracks. (a)–(c) Basin-mean track density (cell⁻¹ month⁻¹) by calendar month for the North Atlantic, the North Pacific, and the Southern Ocean, one line per phase colored by ω , with local summer shaded. (d)–(f) Across-phase range of track density (maximum minus minimum, percent of the phase mean) for the annual mean and the four seasons, with the local-summer bar highlighted; open symbols give the corresponding ranges of system and genesis densities. (g)–(i) Basin-mean track-density anomaly relative to the phase mean as a function of calendar month and precession phase (unsmoothed), with the perihelion (red) and aphelion (blue) calendar months of each phase overlaid.

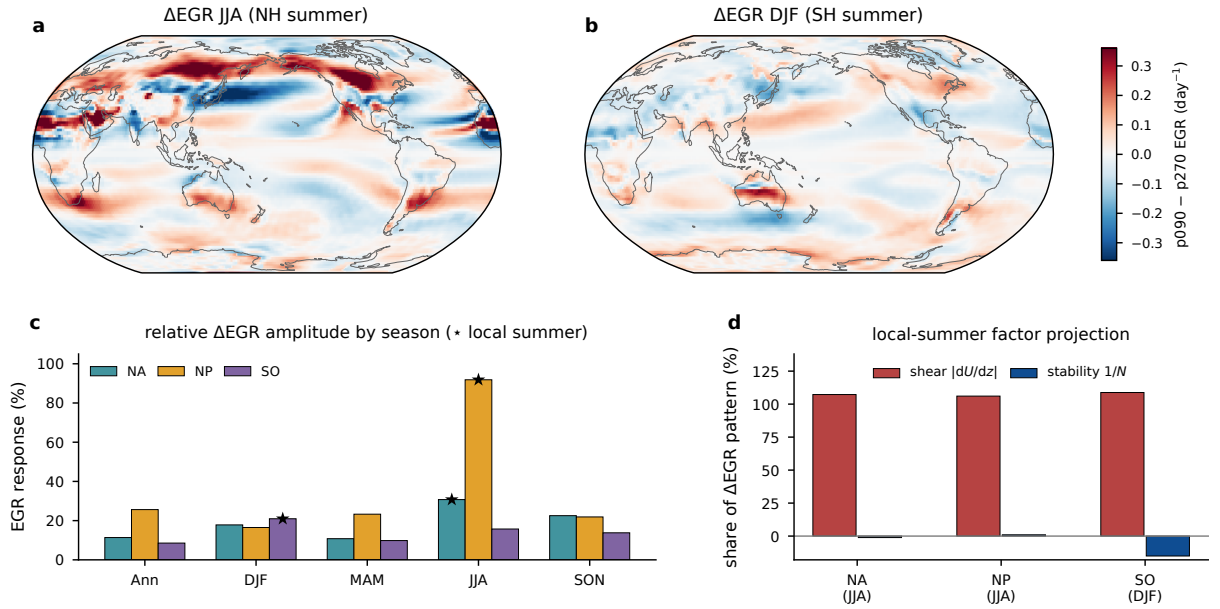


FIG. 5. Precessional response of the maximum Eady growth rate (925–700 hPa). (a) p090 minus p270 difference for JJA and (b) for DJF (day^{-1}). (c) Seasonal response amplitude in each basin, the RMS of the p090 minus p270 difference over the storm box as a percentage of the seasonal climatology, with stars marking local summer. (d) Projection shares of the vertical-shear and static-stability factors in the local-summer difference pattern.

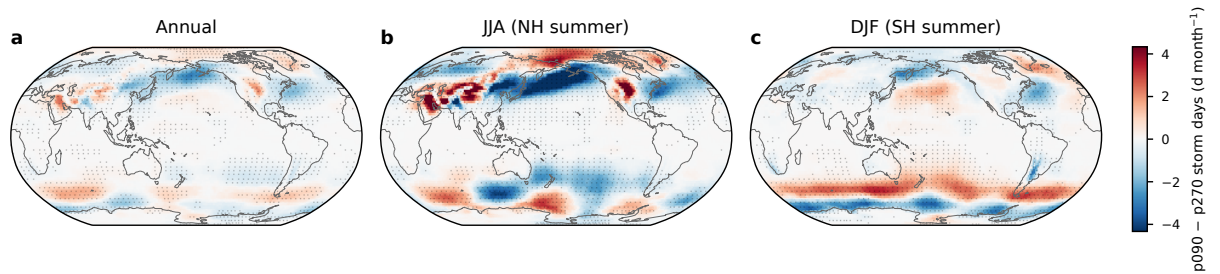


FIG. 6. Difference in storm days (d month^{-1}) between p090 and p270 for (a) the annual mean, (b) JJA, and (c) DJF, on a common color scale. Stippling marks grid points where the difference is significant at the 95% level based on a two-sided Welch t test over the 30 simulated years.

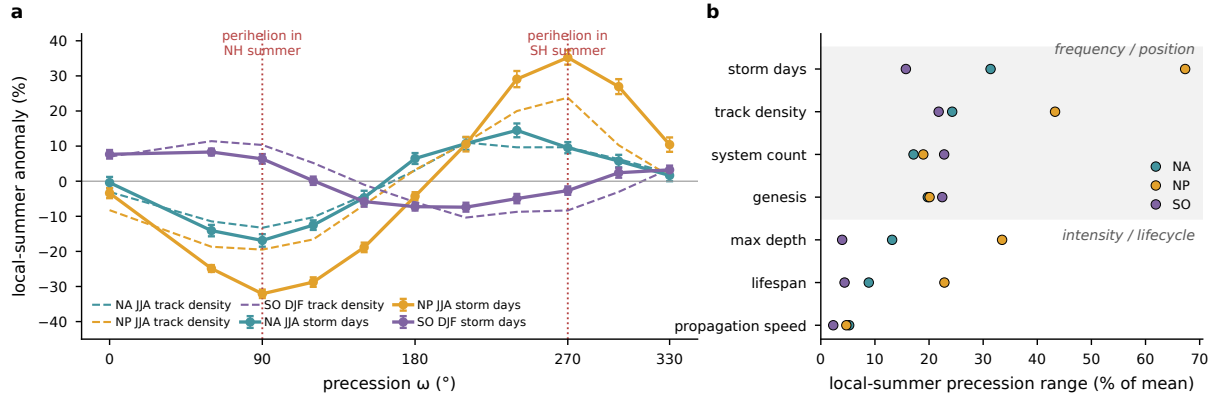


FIG. 7. (a) Local-summer storm activity across the precession cycle, shown as the percent anomaly of basin-mean storm days from the phase mean (solid, with interannual standard errors) and of track density (dashed), for the North Atlantic and the North Pacific in JJA and for the Southern Ocean in DJF; dotted vertical lines mark the phases with perihelion in NH and SH summer. (b) Local-summer across-phase range for frequency and position metrics and for intensity and lifecycle metrics in each basin.

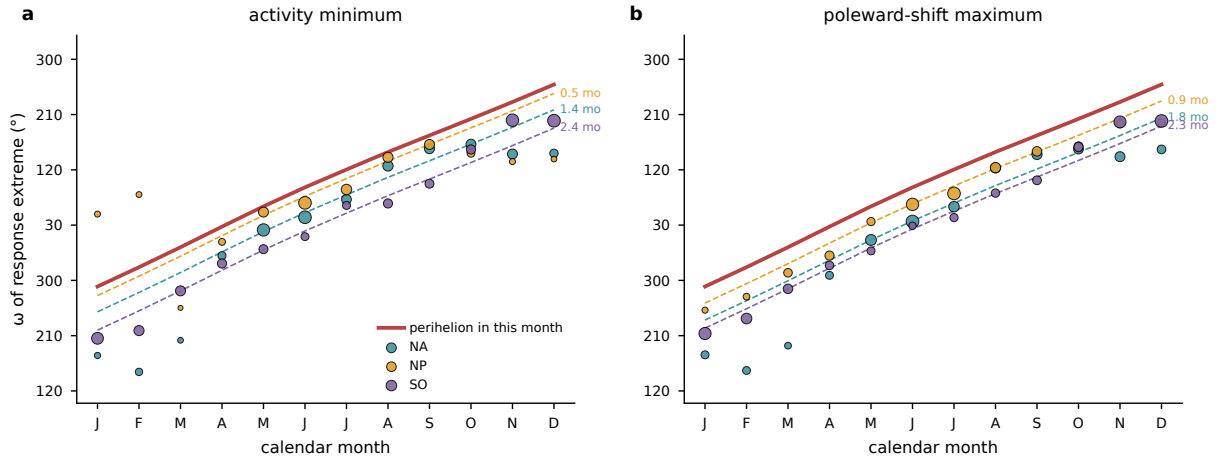


FIG. 8. Phase locking of the storm response to the perihelion calendar. For each calendar month and basin, the phase of the first harmonic across the twelve precession phases of (a) basin-mean storm days, shown as the ω of the activity minimum, and (b) the storm-day-weighted track latitude, shown as the ω of the poleward maximum. Marker size scales with the harmonic amplitude. The red line gives the ω that places perihelion in that calendar month, and dashed lines repeat it delayed by each basin's median lag over the amplitude-strong months (annotated in months).

TABLE 1. Three-basin comparison of the precessional storm response. Ranges are max minus min across the twelve phases as a percentage of the phase mean. Storm and sensitive seasons refer to local winter and local summer. The storm season is diagnosed from cyclogenesis counts, the sensitive season from the seasonal storm-day range. The EGR response is the RMS p090–p270 difference over the basin sector relative to its climatology, and the shear share is the projection of the vertical-shear factor onto the response pattern.

Basin	Storm season	Sensitive season	Storm-day range ann/summer (%)	Summer max/min ω (°)	EGR response summer (%)	Shear share (%)
North Atlantic	DJF	JJA	10 / 32	240 / 90	31	107
North Pacific	DJF	JJA	17 / 68	270 / 90	92	106
Southern Ocean	JJA	DJF	4 / 16	60 / 210	21	109

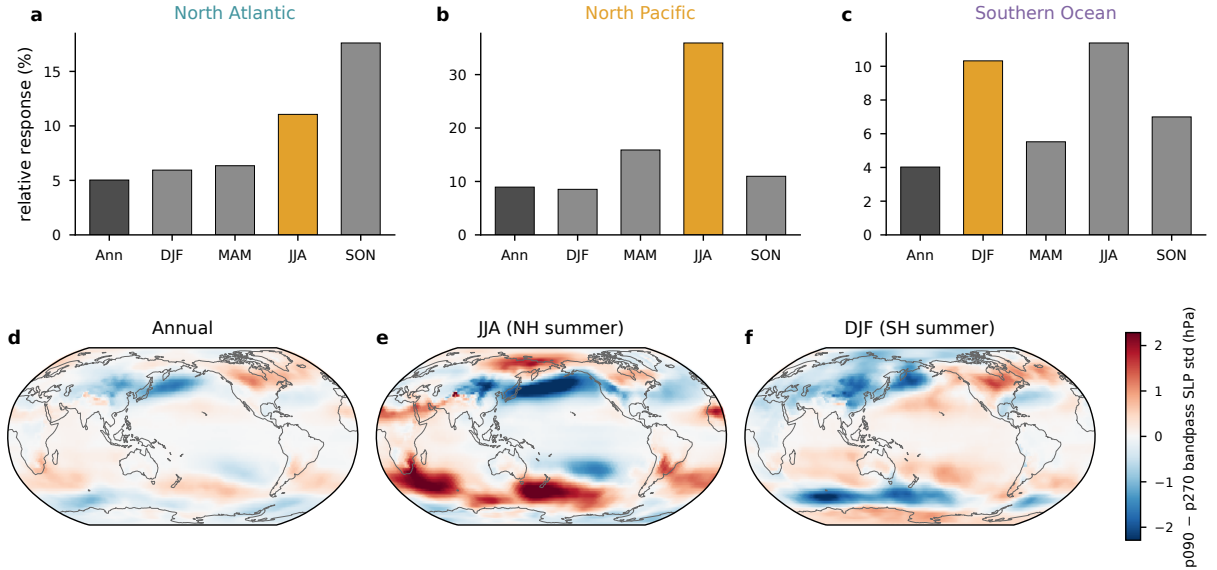


FIG. A1. Tracking-free Eulerian storm-track metric, the monthly standard deviation of 24-h differences of six-hourly sea level pressure. (a)–(c) Relative seasonal response in each basin, the RMS of the p090 minus p270 difference over the storm box as a percentage of the seasonal climatology (as in Fig. 5c), with the local-summer bar highlighted. (d)–(f) The p090 minus p270 difference of the same quantity for the annual mean, JJA, and DJF (hPa).

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Data availability statement. The AWI-ESM simulations of the idealized precession ensemble are described in Shi et al. (2025). The cyclone-track database, the gridded storm statistics, and the analysis scripts underlying all figures will be archived and assigned a DOI upon acceptance. [TODO repository DOI.]

APPENDIX

Tracking-independent, positional, and hydrological diagnostics

Figures A1–A3 present the Eulerian bandpass diagnostic, the seasonal track-latitude analysis, and the storm-attributed precipitation analysis discussed in sections 2 and 3.

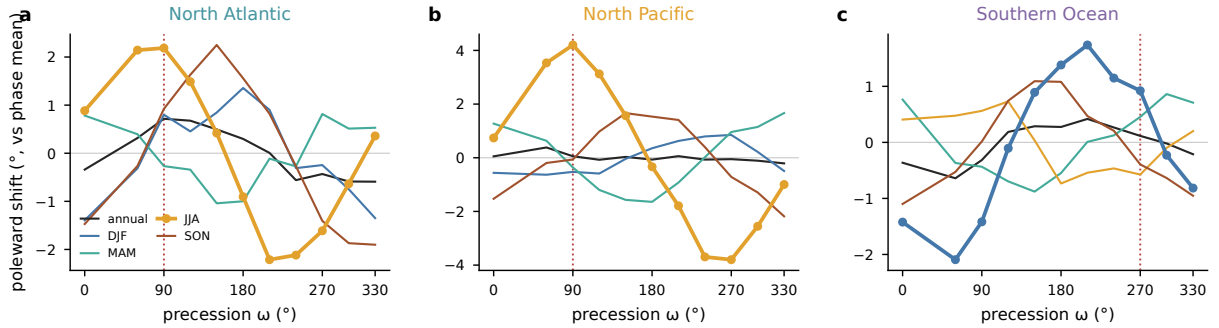


FIG. A2. Storm-track latitude across the precession cycle, the storm-day-weighted mean latitude over each basin sector shown as the poleward anomaly from each season's phase mean, for (a) the North Atlantic, (b) the North Pacific, and (c) the Southern Ocean. Lines give the annual mean and the four seasons, with the local summer of each basin drawn heavy with markers. Vertical dotted lines mark the phase with perihelion in the local summer of each basin.

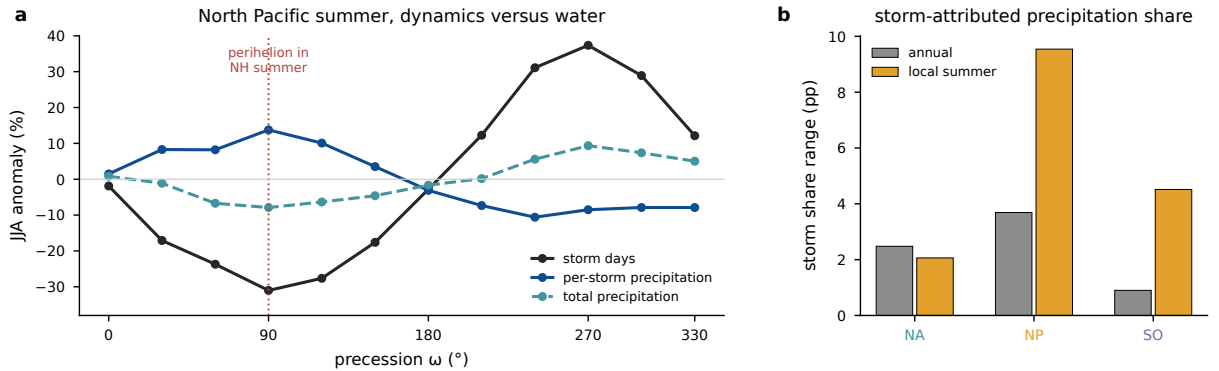


FIG. A3. Storm-attributed precipitation across the precession cycle. (a) North Pacific JJA percent anomalies from the phase mean of basin-mean storm days, per-storm precipitation, and total precipitation; the dotted line marks the phase with perihelion in NH summer. (b) Across-phase range of the storm-attributed share of precipitation, accumulated precipitation inside storm footprints divided by total accumulated precipitation (percentage points), for the annual mean and local summer in each basin.

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